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EDU 101: Foundations of Education - Purpose, History and Practice

What education is for, and how schools actually work

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Education
Educational Foundations | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Education students often memorise definitions without understanding the debates underneath them. This pack covers the meaning and aims of education, major philosophies, the Nigerian education system and the basics of curriculum and assessment.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Distinguish education, schooling and indoctrination.
- Compare major educational philosophies and their classroom implications.
- Describe the structure and levels of the Nigerian education system.
- Explain curriculum, pedagogy and assessment as connected decisions.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What education is

Education is a deliberate process of developing knowledge, skills, attitudes and values. Schooling is one institution through which it happens.

- Formal education is structured and certified; informal education is embedded in daily life; non-formal education is organised but flexible.
- Indoctrination closes inquiry; education opens it. The distinction lies in method and intent.
- Aims include intellectual development, social efficiency, citizenship, moral development and self-actualisation.
- Education is both a right and an instrument of national development.

- Nigerian policy defines basic education broadly, including junior secondary.
- Teachers exercise authority, which makes ethical self-awareness essential.

Educational philosophies

Philosophy answers what knowledge is and what teaching should therefore look like.

- Idealism: emphasises ideas and moral formation; teacher as model.
- Realism: emphasises observation and the natural order.
- Pragmatism and progressivism: learning through experience and problem solving; teacher as facilitator.
- Essentialism: core knowledge and discipline transmitted systematically.
- Constructivism: learners build understanding from prior knowledge and activity.
- Perennialism: enduring ideas and canonical texts.

> **Theory to classroom**
> Examiners love the question 'what does this mean for teaching practice?' Always move from the philosophy to a concrete classroom behaviour.

System, curriculum and assessment

Curriculum is what is intended to be learned; instruction is how it is taught; assessment is how we know whether it was learned.

- Nigerian structure: early childhood, nine years of basic education, three years of senior secondary, then tertiary.
- A curriculum includes objectives, content, methods and evaluation.
- Bloom's taxonomy orders cognitive objectives from remembering to creating.
- Assessment types: diagnostic, formative and summative.
- Valid assessment measures what it claims; reliable assessment is consistent.
- Continuous assessment reduces the weight of a single examination and provides feedback.

What education is for: four competing answers

Every education system rests on an answer to the question "what is education for?", and the answers conflict. The transmission answer says education passes on the knowledge and values a society needs. The developmental answer says it cultivates the whole person. The economic answer says it produces skills for employment and growth. The critical answer says it should equip people to question the society they inherit.

These are not compatible in practice. A curriculum designed for measurable skills crowds out time for open inquiry; a curriculum designed for critical consciousness may not produce the specific competencies employers demand. Recognising the conflict is the first analytic move in this course, because most policy debates are really arguments between these purposes.